Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to make something "correct", **red** often shows up by itself. **The hand reaches for it before the brain has time to call a meeting.** And that is exactly what is **interesting** about it. Sometimes we know exactly **why**, at other times not at all. **Both are fine.**

What can hide behind a red stroke

The same red line on paper can mean **something completely different** depending on what is going on in us. Sometimes it is **a scream, at other times an embrace**, sometimes pure joy in the colour. That is why it **makes no sense** to read a painting as a test with **one right answer**.

Anger that we would never say out loud.

The stroke tends to be sharp, fast and strong, sometimes even tearing the paper.

Longing for closeness

for touch, for someone to notice us.

The stroke tends to be flowing, circular and softer.

Zest for life and energy.

Large areas, a lot of paint and joy in the movement of the hand.

Fear or tension.

Small, tightly drawn spots, hard outlines, red kept at the edge of the paper.

Courage or defiance.

Red that plants itself in the middle and refuses to be overpowered.

Sadness or loss.

Red that we choose because no other colour is strong enough.

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Red in a painting. Can it express what is going on inside?

Yes, it **can** – but it **does not have to**. When you paint, you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Red can then give form to rage, pain, defiance, desire or the simple feeling of "there is so much in me".

It can just as well belong to joy and the wish to live again. It gains **meaning** only in connection with **your experience**. **The colour itself does not know what happened to you.** You do – or you will work it out in time.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters is not a single patch of colour but **the whole picture** and how it came to be. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting.

A predominance of red alone **is not enough for a verdict** of "this is anger". Maybe you were angry. Maybe you wanted to cover a previous layer. And maybe you simply enjoyed that red so much that pastel had no chance that day.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A red painting and a red dress may ask two completely different things of you. On **canvas** you give **space to an experience**. In clothing you may feel you are putting yourself on show. That is why a large red area in a painting can attract you while the thought of walking among people in a red coat frightens you.

Perhaps you need to express a strength you have held inside for a long time, but you do not yet want to stand out in front of others. **The canvas can be a safe place** where you allow yourself to express in your own way.

This is one possible connection; sometimes the explanation is much simpler – a different taste for pictures and for a wardrobe. And even after ten red paintings **you do not have to start wearing a red dress. No obligation comes out of it.**

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When red takes over the space

Let red take as much room **as you want**. You do not have to soften it right away, balance it or defend it. Later you can notice what is going on in you. Relief, joy, tiredness, or on the contrary more tension.

Not even relief automatically proves a specific meaning of the colour, and after painting you do not have to feel reborn. If painting starts to **wind you up** instead, feel free to **put the colours aside**. **A pause is part of the work too**.

Three things worth noticing

QUANTITY

A small flash, or the whole surface?

A tiny red mark can be the centre of the whole painting for you. A large area can feel strong, lively and free, or it can become too loud. A large red area is not proof of great anger, and a small mark does not mean you do not dare to claim your strength.

SATURATION

Saturated, or gentle?

Pure red has the look of a ripe cherry or a poppy flower. With white it turns pink or coral, with brown or ochre it comes close to brick and clay. If a wave of relief washes over you after adding white, that very change is interesting. Perhaps a less urgent look suits you today. You do not have to draw a conclusion about your whole personality from it.

THICKNESS

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push, spread and leave a mark in. Thin paint flows and runs and may surprise you with a direction you had not planned. Sometimes you enjoy the substance and resistance, at other times the chance to let go of control and watch what happens. It is not a test of courage. A careful, thin stroke can be exactly your language for today.

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What to take from the picture

It is not about whether a red stroke looks “right”. What matters more is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is going on in your life right now. Two almost identical pictures can have a completely different story. One was made after an argument, the other after a long time alone. That is why you will not find a **dictionary** here of the “red = anger” kind, but **questions**. **Life will not fit into a single colour chart anyway**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps after a while you will notice that you kept returning to red in a period when you lacked **support**, **courage** or the wish to be seen. Perhaps you will link it with a completely **different experience**. In self-reflective work inspired by art therapy, a picture can serve as a trace of **your own experience** and a chance to look back.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at a picture and it tells you nothing at all. Just colour, strokes, done. And a week, a month or a year later it suddenly comes: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in me back then.” That is fine. **The picture is not going anywhere**. **You do not have to** squeeze an **answer** out of it with a still-wet brush.

Neither is wrong and neither is right. Anger, longing, fear and zest for life all belong to you, and red can **carry everything**.

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